Forty Years in the Desert

Numbers 13–14 · Numbers 20–21 · Deuteronomy 8

The big idea: Israel saw the grapes and believed the giants, and a whole generation died in the desert. Yet God fed them, led them, and carried them. When serpents bit them, God told them to look at a bronze serpent and live.

Before you meet: Read

Numbers 13:25–14:10 | Numbers 21:4–9 | Deuteronomy 8:2–4 | John 3:14–16

Open (5 minutes)

Think of a time fear kept you from doing something you knew was right. What were you afraid of?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"It is eleven _____ journey from Horeb by the way of Mount Seir to Kadesh-barnea." *(Deuteronomy 1:2)*

"If the LORD _____ in us, he will bring us into this land and give it to us." *(Numbers 14:8)*

"And if a serpent bit anyone, he would _____ at the bronze serpent and _____." *(Numbers 21:9)*

Discuss

1. Caleb and Joshua saw the same giants as the other ten spies. What made the difference? *Numbers 13:30; 14:6–9*

2. God forgave Israel but still let them face forty years of consequences. How do forgiveness and consequences fit together in your own life? *Numbers 14:20–24*

3. Jesus said the bronze serpent was a picture of him. What does it teach about what it means to believe? *John 3:14–15*

Memory verse

> *"And as Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, so must the Son of Man be lifted up, that whoever believes in him may have eternal life."*
>
> **John 3:14–15**

Pray

Name your giants to God. Thank him for five ways he has provided for you this year, and look to Jesus, lifted up for you.

LEADER NOTES · WEEK 23

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Session plan (about 45 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Numbers 14:1–10 and 21:4–9 aloud together.
5 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
20 min	Discuss: choose three of the questions.
5 min	Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (Deuteronomy 6:4–9 and 34, and Joshua 1–6).

Main points to land

1. Unbelief, not giants, kept Israel out of the land. The ten spies saw the fruit and still would not trust God (Numbers 14:11; Hebrews 3:19).
2. In the wilderness God disciplined his people as a Father and carried them the whole way: manna, water, clothing that did not wear out (Deuteronomy 8:2–5; 1:31).
3. The bronze serpent shows what faith is: a look of trust at the One God has lifted up (Numbers 21:9; John 3:14–15).

Core doctrine to teach

Saving Faith CORE DOCTRINE 12 OF 26

Faith is trusting God's promise and resting on Christ alone for salvation. Israel saw God's miracles in the wilderness, yet they could not enter the land because of unbelief. Faith is leaning our whole weight on what God has said. It is not a work that earns anything. *Numbers 14:11; Hebrews 3:19; 11:6; John 3:16*

Answer key (Observe)

1. days'
2. delights
3. look; live

Questions people will ask

Why was Moses kept out of the land for one mistake?

God said Moses did not trust him or honor him as holy before the people (Numbers 20:12). Leaders are held to a high standard. But God still let Moses see the land, buried him himself, and later brought him into the land to speak with Jesus at the transfiguration (Matthew 17:3). His exclusion from Canaan was discipline. It was never a loss of salvation.

Closing prayer

Father, forgive us for believing the giants instead of you. Thank you that you carried your people through the desert anyway. Thank you for Jesus, lifted up on the cross so that everyone who looks to him in faith may live. Amen.